Types of Prompts — A Practical Guide

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Introduction

There are nine core prompt types every LLM user should know. Each one changes how much guidance the model gets: examples, a role, reasoning steps, context, a format, or limits.

A prompt is the input you give a large language model to get an output. The same model can give a vague answer or an excellent one depending on how the prompt is built.

Each section below gives the definition, the reasons to use that type, and five examples across everyday, business, software and banking scenarios. In practice, strong prompts combine several types at once.

1. Zero-shot prompting

Definition: You give the model a task with no examples and rely entirely on what it already learned in training.

Reasons to use it

- Fastest to write; ideal for common, well-understood tasks.
- Shows the model's baseline ability before you invest in a more complex prompt.
- Uses the fewest tokens, so it is the cheapest option.
- Works well with modern instruction-tuned models for general tasks.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Translation	Translate "Your account statement is ready" into Hindi.
2	Sentiment	Classify this review as positive, negative or neutral: "The app keeps logging me out."
3	Summary	Summarise the following meeting notes in three sentences.
4	Code	Write a Java method that checks whether a string is a palindrome.
5	Explanation	Explain what IBM MQ is to a fresher in simple terms.

2. One-shot and few-shot prompting

Definition: You include one (one-shot) or several (few-shot) input–output examples in the prompt, so the model copies the pattern, tone or format.

Reasons to use it

- Teaches a custom format or label set that the model cannot guess.
- Gives far more consistent output than zero-shot for classification and extraction.
- Conveys tone and style faster than describing them in words.
- Avoids fine-tuning: the examples act as lightweight, in-context training.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Ticket routing	"Card blocked" → Cards. "Loan EMI query" → Loans. "Net banking login failed" → Digital. Now classify: "UPI payment pending" →

2	Data extraction	Text: "Ravi paid ₹5,000 on 3 Oct" → {name: Ravi, amount: 5000, date: 03-Oct}. Text: "Meena paid ₹1,200 on 9 Oct" →
3	Brand tone	Here are two of our past LinkedIn posts: [post 1] [post 2]. Write a new post announcing our AWS workshop in the same style.
4	Code convention	Here is how we name REST endpoints: GET /customers/{id}, POST /customers. Write endpoints for the Accounts resource.
5	Quiz writing	Q: What does JVM stand for? A) Java Virtual Machine ✔️ B) Java Variable Method. Write five more questions like this on Spring Boot.

3. Role (persona) prompting

Definition: You assign the model an identity, expertise or audience perspective ("You are a…") so it answers from that viewpoint.

Reasons to use it

- Sets vocabulary, depth and tone in a single line.
- Pulls in domain-specific framing, such as compliance thinking for a banking auditor.
- Makes the answer fit the audience, from a CXO to a fresher.
- Useful for practice and simulation, such as mock interviews or customer role-plays.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Code review	You are a senior Java architect. Review this Spring Boot service for performance and security issues.
2	Compliance	You are an RBI compliance officer. List the risks in this customer-onboarding process.
3	Interview practice	Act as an interviewer for an AWS Solutions Architect role. Ask me one question at a time and rate my answers.
4	Teaching	You are a patient school teacher. Explain cloud computing to a 12-year-old using a lunchbox analogy.
5	Customer simulation	Play an angry bank customer whose cheque bounced. I am the branch manager; respond to my replies in character.

4. Instruction prompting

Definition: You give clear, explicit, step-by-step directions describing exactly what the model must do, often as a numbered list of tasks.

Reasons to use it

- Removes ambiguity, so the model does not guess your intent.
- Ensures every required part of a multi-part task is covered.
- Makes outputs repeatable across runs and across team members.
- Easy to review and debug: you can see which instruction was missed.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Email	Write an email to the client. 1) Thank them for the meeting. 2) Confirm the training dates. 3) Attach the agenda. 4) Keep it under 120 words.
2	Document review	Read this policy. First list the key rules, then flag anything unclear, then suggest two improvements.

3	Code refactor	Refactor this method: rename variables meaningfully, add null checks, add JavaDoc, and do not change the logic.
4	Lesson plan	Create a 2-hour lesson plan on DB2 basics with objectives, three activities, timings and a 5-question recap.
5	Report	Analyse this sales data: compute monthly totals, identify the top 3 products, and write a two-line conclusion.

5. Chain-of-thought (CoT) prompting

Definition: You ask the model to reason step by step before giving the final answer, either by saying so ("think step by step") or by showing a worked example of the reasoning.

Reasons to use it

- Improves accuracy on maths, logic and multi-step problems.
- Makes the reasoning visible, so you can spot where it went wrong.
- Reduces careless jumps to a wrong conclusion.
- Builds trust in decisions that need justification, such as approvals or diagnoses.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Finance maths	A loan of ₹5,00,000 at 9% annual interest for 3 years. Work out the EMI step by step, then give the final figure.
2	Debugging	This Java code throws a NullPointerException. Walk through the execution line by line and find the cause.
3	Decision	Should we move this batch job from IBM i to AWS Lambda? Reason through cost, latency and risk, then recommend.
4	Logic puzzle	If all managers are employees and some employees are trainers, can we conclude some managers are trainers? Think step by step.
5	Capacity planning	Our API gets 2 million calls a day with peaks at 5x average. Reason step by step to estimate the peak requests per second.

6. Contextual prompting

Definition: You supply background information — the situation, audience, goal, documents or data — so the model answers for your specific case rather than generically.

Reasons to use it

- Turns generic answers into ones that fit your actual situation.
- Grounds the answer in your documents, which reduces hallucination.
- Lets the model work on private or recent information it was never trained on.
- This is the idea behind RAG: retrieved documents are context added to the prompt.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Training design	My audience is 20 mainframe developers moving to Java with no Spring experience. Suggest a 5-day Spring Boot agenda.
2	Document Q&A	Using only the attached loan policy document, answer: what is the maximum tenure for a home loan?
3	Proposal	Our client is a mid-size bank migrating from IBM MQ to Kafka within 6 months on a fixed budget. Draft the approach section.

4	Incident analysis	Here are the server logs from 2:00–2:15 AM and the alert we received. Explain what likely caused the outage.
5	Personal advice	I'm repainting a north-facing living room with low natural light. Suggest three wall colours and why they suit it.

7. Structured output (format) prompting

Definition: You specify the exact shape of the response — JSON, a table, bullet points, a template, headings or a word limit.

Reasons to use it

- Output can be read directly by code or pasted into tools without cleanup.
- Makes results easy to compare and scan.
- Keeps reports and documents consistent across a team.
- Essential when an LLM feeds an application or another agent.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	API integration	Extract customer name, account type and branch from this text. Return only JSON with keys name, accountType, branch.
2	Comparison	Compare AWS, Azure and GCP for a startup as a table with columns: Service, Pricing model, Free tier, Best for.
3	Meeting minutes	Summarise this call using exactly these headings: Decisions, Action items (owner, due date), Open questions.
4	Social post	Write a LinkedIn post on GenAI in banking: a one-line hook, three bullet points, a closing question, max 150 words.
5	Test cases	Generate test cases for the login API as a CSV with columns: ID, Scenario, Input, Expected result.

8. Prompt chaining

Definition: You split a large task into a sequence of smaller prompts, where the output of one step becomes the input of the next.

Reasons to use it

- Each step is simpler, so the model does it more reliably.
- You can check and correct the output between steps.
- Failures are easy to locate to a single step.
- It is the foundation of agentic workflows and multi-step AI pipelines.

Examples

#	Use case	Chain of prompts
1	Blog writing	(1) Suggest 5 titles on Agentic AI → (2) Outline the chosen title → (3) Write each section → (4) Proofread and shorten.
2	Code delivery	(1) Write requirements for a fund-transfer API → (2) Design the classes → (3) Generate code → (4) Generate unit tests for it.
3	Research	(1) Extract key points from each of 3 articles → (2) Find where they agree and differ → (3) Write a one-page summary.
4	Customer support	(1) Classify the complaint → (2) Pull the matching policy → (3) Draft a reply → (4) Check the reply's tone for politeness.

5	Course building	(1) Define learning outcomes → (2) Create modules for each → (3) Write labs per module → (4) Write the final assessment.

9. Constraint-based and negative prompting

Definition: You set limits and boundaries — length, scope, reading level, allowed sources — and state what the model must not do.

Reasons to use it

- Keeps the answer focused and the right length.
- Prevents unwanted content: jargon, speculation, sensitive data, made-up facts.
- Supports compliance and safety rules in regulated industries such as banking.
- Saves tokens and editing time.

Tip: Pair every "don't" with a "do instead" — models follow positive instructions more reliably than prohibitions alone.

Examples

#	Use case	Prompt
1	Length limit	Explain Kubernetes in exactly 50 words. Do not use the words "container orchestration".
2	No hallucination	Answer only from the text provided. If the answer is not in it, reply "Not found in document".
3	Data privacy	Summarise this complaint. Do not include account numbers or phone numbers; refer to the customer as "the customer".
4	Audience level	Explain blockchain for bank tellers. No technical jargon, no code, use one real-life analogy.
5	Scope control	Suggest Java performance fixes. Use only Java 17 standard libraries; do not suggest third-party frameworks.

Quick-selection guide

Pick the type by what the model is missing; combine types for anything important.

Prompt type	What it adds	Use when	Watch out for
Zero-shot	Nothing extra	Task is common and simple	Generic or inconsistent output
One/few-shot	Examples	You need a specific pattern or label set	Model over-copies examples; keep them varied
Role	A perspective	Tone, depth or expertise matters	A role does not add real knowledge
Instruction	Explicit steps	Multi-part tasks with requirements	Too many rules can conflict
Chain-of-thought	Reasoning	Maths, logic, decisions	Longer, costlier responses
Contextual	Your facts and data	Answer depends on your situation	Long context raises cost
Structured output	A format	Output feeds code or a template	Validate JSON before using it
Prompt chaining	A pipeline	Large tasks with distinct stages	More calls, more latency
Constraint / negative	Boundaries	Length, safety, compliance limits	State what to do, not only what not to do

Combined example: *You are a senior banking business analyst* (role). *Our bank is launching UPI autopay for SME customers* (context). *Think through the risks step by step* (chain-of-thought), *then list the top 5 as a table with columns Risk, Impact, Mitigation* (structured output). *Keep it under 200 words and avoid legal advice* (constraints).